

HR and behavioural interview guide

For final-year students facing campus placement HR rounds: what interviewers look for, the STAR method, 18 common questions with sample answers, etiquette, group discussions and a last-week checklist.

1. What the HR round is really checking

By the time you reach HR, the company usually knows you can do the basic work. The HR round checks whether you will fit in, stay, communicate clearly and behave professionally. There is rarely one "correct" answer. Interviewers judge *how* you think and speak as much as *what* you say.

What they assess	How it shows up in the interview
Communication	Clear, structured answers in simple English. Not fluency or accent, but whether you can be understood.
Honesty and consistency	Your answers match your resume and each other. Exaggeration is easy to spot with one follow-up question.
Attitude and willingness to learn	How you talk about failures, feedback, new technologies and tasks you did not choose.
Teamwork	Whether you say "we" and "I" in the right places, and how you describe disagreements.
Commitment and flexibility	Questions on relocation, shifts, service agreements (bond) and long-term plans.
Self-awareness	Can you name real strengths and real weaknesses, with examples?
Company interest	Do you know what the company does, or are you applying everywhere blindly?

Tip: HR rounds at large service companies are often short (10 to 20 minutes) and may be combined with the technical round. Product companies and startups often run a separate "behavioural" or "hiring manager" round that goes deeper into past projects and decisions. Prepare for both styles.

2. The STAR method

Behavioural questions start with phrases like "Tell me about a time when...", "Give an example of...", or "Describe a situation where...". The interviewer wants a real story from your past, not an opinion about what you would do. STAR keeps that story short and complete.

Letter	Meaning	What to say	Share of answer
S	Situation	Where and when. One or two sentences of context.	About 15%
T	Task	What you were responsible for, or the problem to solve.	About 10%
A	Action	What <i>you</i> did, step by step. Use "I", not only "we".	About 55%
R	Result	What happened. Use numbers if they are true. Add what you learned.	About 20%

The percentages are a rough guide, not a rule. The key point: most of your time should go on **Action**. Many students spend a full minute on background and then say "and we finished it" in one line.

Fully worked example

Question: "Tell me about a time you faced a tight deadline."

Weak answer

"In our final-year project we had a lot of pressure and a tight deadline, but we all worked hard as a team and completed it on time. I am good at working under pressure."

This is vague. There is no detail, no personal action and no result anyone can check.

STAR answer

Situation: "In my sixth semester, my team of four was building a library management web app for our mini-project. Two weeks before the demo, one teammate fell ill and could not work on the backend he owned."

Task: "I was handling the frontend, but someone had to finish the book-issue and return APIs, or the demo would not work end to end."

Action: "First, I listed what was left in his module and found five endpoints, of which two were done. I spoke to him on call for thirty minutes to understand his database schema so I did not have to guess. I then split the work: I took the three remaining APIs, and another teammate took over some of my frontend screens. I wrote the APIs in Node and Express over four evenings, and tested each one with Postman before connecting it to the UI. I also set up a shared checklist so we could see daily what was finished."

Result: "We demoed the full flow on time and the project got an A grade. What I learned is that writing down the remaining work early makes a deadline feel manageable. I now do this at the start of every project."

Tip: Prepare 5 to 6 STAR stories in advance from projects, internships, hackathons, college events, sports or part-time work. One good story can answer several questions: teamwork, conflict, deadline, leadership, failure. Write each one in about 120 to 150 words and practise saying it aloud in under two minutes.

3. "Tell me about yourself"

This is usually the first question, and it sets the tone for the rest. It is not a request to recite your resume or your family history. It is a 60 to 90 second professional introduction that leads naturally into topics you are ready to discuss.

A simple structure: Present, Past, Future

1. **Present:** Who you are now. Name, degree, college, year. One line.
2. **Past:** Two or three highlights that matter for this job: a project, an internship, a skill, an achievement. Give one concrete detail for each.
3. **Future:** Why you are here. What kind of role you want and how it connects to this company.

Sample for a final-year CS student

"Tell me about yourself."

"Good morning. I am Priya Sharma, a final-year B.Tech Computer Science student at [college name], with a CGPA of 8.1. I enjoy backend development and problem solving. Over the last two years I have solved around 300 problems on coding platforms, mostly in Java, which helped me get comfortable with data structures. My main project is an attendance system that uses face recognition. I built the backend in Spring Boot with a MySQL database, and it is used in one of our department labs. Last summer I did a six-week internship at a local startup, where I wrote REST APIs and learnt how code reviews and Git workflows happen in a real team. Outside academics, I coordinated our college coding club's weekly contests. I am looking to start my career in a role where I can build reliable software and keep learning, and [company]'s work in [specific area] is the kind of work I want to be part of."

Replace every detail with your own true facts. Never claim a number you cannot defend in a follow-up question. If you have solved 300 problems, expect "What was the hardest one?"

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Keep it to 60 to 90 seconds.	Starting with your father's occupation, hometown and schooling in detail.
Mention things you want them to ask about.	Mentioning a skill you only watched one video on.
Sound natural, as if speaking to a senior.	Reciting a memorised paragraph word for word, with no pauses.
End by linking to the role.	Ending with "...that's it" or "that's all about me".

A short line about hobbies is fine if it is genuine and you can talk about it. If you say "reading", be ready to name the last book you read.

4. Common HR and behavioural questions

For each question: what the interviewer is looking for, and a short sample answer. Treat the samples as patterns. Use your own true examples. Interviewers hear the same memorised answers from hundreds of students, and a real, specific answer stands out.

Self and motivation

Q1. What are your strengths?

Looking for: Self-awareness and proof. A strength without an example is just a claim.

Sample: "One strength is that I am consistent. When I started DSA practice in second year, I set a goal of solving at least one problem every day, and I kept it up for most of the year. The same habit helped in my project, where I pushed small updates daily instead of rushing at the end."

Q2. What is your biggest weakness?

Looking for: Honesty, and evidence that you are working on it. Avoid fake weaknesses like "I am a perfectionist" or "I work too hard". Also avoid weaknesses that are core to the job (for a developer, "I don't like coding").

Sample: "I used to hesitate to speak in group settings, even when I had a useful point. In my internship I noticed I stayed quiet in stand-up meetings. Since then I have made it a rule to share at least one update or question in every team meeting, and I volunteered to present our project review in college. I am more comfortable now, though I am still improving."

Q3. Why do you want to join our company?

Looking for: Basic research and real interest. Generic answers like "it is a big MNC with good growth" show no preparation.

Sample: "I read that your company works with clients across banking and retail, so freshers get exposure to different domains early. I also saw that new joiners go through a structured training program, which matters to me because I want a strong foundation before specialising. And from talking to a senior from my college who works here, I understood the teams encourage learning new technologies, which matches how I like to work."

Tip: Before each interview, spend 20 minutes on the company's official website (About, Services or Products, recent news), plus its careers page. Note 2 or 3 specific facts. Do not quote numbers like revenue or headcount unless you are sure they are current.

Q4. Where do you see yourself in five years?

Looking for: Ambition that is realistic and connected to the company. They also want a hint that you will not leave in six months. Avoid "in your chair" or "running my own startup" unless you can explain it well.

Sample: "In five years, I want to be a strong developer who is trusted with important modules, and who can guide new team members. I would like to have gone deep in one area, probably backend or cloud, and to have earned the relevant certifications along the way. I see myself growing within a company that gives me that kind of responsibility over time."

Q5. Why should we hire you?

Looking for: A short summary that matches your skills to their needs. Confidence without arrogance. Do not compare yourself with other candidates.

Sample: "You need freshers who can pick up technologies quickly and work well in teams. I have a solid base in Java and SQL, I have applied them in a real project and an internship, and I have shown I can learn on my own, for example I learnt Spring Boot for my project. I am also flexible about the role and location, and ready to put in the effort during training."

Job conditions

Q6. Are you willing to relocate?

Looking for: Flexibility, but also honesty. Service companies often assign locations based on project need.

Sample: "Yes, I am open to relocating. Moving to a new city would also help me become more independent." If you genuinely have a constraint (for example, a family health situation), say so politely and briefly. Saying "yes" now and refusing the posting later harms you more.

Q7. Are you comfortable working in shifts or night shifts?

Looking for: Whether you understand that client-facing and support projects may follow other time zones.

Sample: "Yes. I understand some projects support clients in other time zones, and I am comfortable adjusting my schedule when the project needs it." Again, if you have a real limitation, state it honestly instead of agreeing to everything.

Q8. Are you okay with signing a service agreement (bond)?

Looking for: Commitment, and that you have read the terms instead of being surprised later.

Sample: "Yes. I understand the company invests in training freshers, and I plan to stay and grow here, so the agreement is not a concern for me. I have read the terms in the offer details." Before you say this, actually read the terms: duration, conditions and any amount payable if you leave early. Ask the placement cell if anything is unclear.

Q9. What are your salary expectations?

Looking for: For campus hiring, the package is usually fixed and announced beforehand. They mainly want to see you are not unreasonable.

Sample (campus): "As a fresher, my priority is learning and a good start to my career. I am comfortable with the package your company has offered for this role." *Sample (off-campus, if no figure is announced):* "I would expect a package in line with the industry standard for this role and location. Could you share the range you have in mind?" Research typical ranges for the role beforehand from your placement cell or seniors so you are not caught off guard.

Q10. Do you have other offers? / Will you leave if you get a better offer?

Looking for: Honesty and seriousness about this opportunity.

Sample: "I have [no other offer yet / an offer from X]. I applied here because the role and training match what I want. If selected, I intend to join and build my career here." Do not lie about offers. Many colleges have placement rules about multiple offers; know them.

Behavioural (use STAR)

Q11. Tell me about a time you failed.

Looking for: Ownership and learning. Do not blame others, and do not pick a "failure" that was secretly a success.

Sample: "In my third year I signed up for a 36-hour hackathon and planned a very ambitious app with machine learning, a mobile frontend and a backend. I spent the first twelve hours on the ML model alone, and at the end we had nothing working to demo. We did not get shortlisted. I realised I had not scoped the problem. Since then I start every project by defining the smallest version that works, and I build that first. In the next hackathon we used this approach and reached the final round."

Q12. Describe a conflict with a teammate and how you handled it.

Looking for: Maturity. You listened, focused on the problem rather than the person, and reached a solution.

Sample: "During our final-year project, a teammate and I disagreed on the database: he wanted MongoDB, I wanted MySQL. The argument was delaying our work. I suggested we each list the pros and cons for our specific data. When we wrote it down, our data was clearly relational with many joins, so we chose MySQL, but we used his idea of storing logs as JSON. He felt heard, and we finished the schema the same day. I learnt that comparing options on paper removes ego from the discussion."

Q13. Tell me about a time you worked in a team.

Looking for: What *your* role was, how you coordinated, and the outcome.

Sample: "For our college tech fest, I was one of five volunteers managing online registrations. My job was the registration form and the participant database. I coordinated daily with the events team so each event's seat limit was reflected in the form. When an event filled up early, I closed it and added a waitlist within an hour. We handled registrations for all events without double-booking, and the same system was reused the next year."

Q14. Give an example of when you showed leadership.

Looking for: Initiative and responsibility. You do not need a formal title; leadership can mean organising, guiding or taking ownership.

Sample: "When I noticed many juniors in my department struggling with their first coding contest, I proposed weekly practice sessions to our coding club. I prepared problem sets, took the first few sessions myself, and then rotated sessions among seniors so it did not depend on one person. Attendance grew from about 10 to 30 students over the semester, and the sessions continued after I handed over."

Q15. How do you handle pressure or criticism?

Looking for: Calmness and a practical method, with an example.

Sample: "I try to separate the feedback from my feelings and look at what can be fixed. In my internship, my mentor rejected my first pull request with many comments on naming and missing tests. I felt bad at first, but I went through each comment, fixed them, and asked him two questions where I did not understand. My next pull requests needed far fewer changes, and I now check those points before submitting."

Q16. Tell me about a time you learnt something new quickly.

Looking for: Learning ability, which matters a lot for freshers who will be trained on new technologies.

Sample: "In my internship, I was asked to add a feature to a React app, but I had only used plain HTML and JavaScript. I took two days to go through the official React tutorial and rebuilt a small part of the app's UI as practice. By the end of the first week I submitted the feature, with help from my mentor on state management. It taught me to learn from official documentation and to practise on a small piece first."

Other common ones**Q17. Explain the gap in your education / your backlog / your low marks.**

Looking for: Honesty and what you did about it. Do not hide or make up stories.

Sample: "I had a backlog in Mathematics in my second year. I was not managing my time well between subjects. I cleared it in the next attempt, and since then I plan my preparation weekly. My scores in the last four semesters have been more consistent."

Q18. Do you have any questions for us?

Looking for: Genuine interest. "No questions" can come across as low interest. Ask one or two thoughtful questions. Avoid asking about leave or salary hikes in the first interview.

Good questions to ask:

- "What does the training program for freshers cover, and how long is it?"
- "What technologies or domains do freshers usually work on in their first year?"
- "What qualities do the freshers who do well here have in common?"
- "Is there anything I can learn before joining that would help me contribute faster?"
- "How is performance reviewed for new joiners?"

Quick reference: tricky one-liners

Question	Good direction
"Why are you not going for higher studies?"	You want industry experience first; you may study later with clear goals. Be honest if you plan an MS soon.
"Why IT, when you studied mechanical/ECE?"	A specific moment you got into coding, plus what you did about it (courses, projects).
"What do you know about our company?"	Two or three specific facts from your research, not a recited Wikipedia paragraph.
"Rate yourself in Java out of 10."	Be modest and specific: "About 7. I am comfortable with OOP and collections, still learning multithreading."
"What motivates you?"	Solving problems, seeing something you built being used, learning. Give one example.
"Describe yourself in three words."	Three words, each with a one-line example.

5. Body language and in-person etiquette

- **Arrive early.** Reach 15 to 20 minutes before your slot. Carry printed copies of your resume, ID proof, and any documents the placement cell asked for, in a neat folder.
- **Dress:** Formal and clean. A plain shirt, formal trousers and polished shoes, or a formal salwar suit or saree. Simple is better than fancy.
- **Greeting:** Greet with "Good morning" or "Good afternoon". Wait to be offered a seat, or ask "May I sit?". Thank them at the end.
- **Posture:** Sit upright, slightly forward. Keep hands relaxed on the table or lap. Avoid crossing arms, shaking legs, or playing with a pen.
- **Eye contact:** Look at the interviewer while speaking and listening. With a panel, look mainly at the person who asked, then include the others.
- **Voice:** Speak at a steady pace. It is fine to pause for two or three seconds to think. Say "Let me think for a moment" instead of filling silence with "umm".
- **Listening:** Do not interrupt. If you did not understand a question, ask: "Could you please repeat that?"
- **Phone:** Switch it to silent before entering. Do not keep it on the table.

6. Online interview etiquette

Area	What to do
Setup check	Test the platform link, camera, microphone and internet a day before and again 15 minutes before. Keep a mobile hotspot ready as a backup.
Camera	Keep the camera at eye level. Your face and shoulders should be visible. Look at the camera when speaking, not at your own video.
Lighting	Light should be in front of you (a window or lamp facing you), not behind you.
Background	A plain wall or tidy room. Avoid busy or funny virtual backgrounds.
Audio	Use earphones with a mic to avoid echo. Ask family members for silence during the slot. Mute only if there is unavoidable noise.
Dress	Dress formally, fully. You may need to stand up or adjust the camera.
Name	Set your display name to your full name as on your resume, not a nickname.
Screen	Close other tabs, notifications and apps. If you need to share your screen for a coding task, make sure nothing private is visible.
Honesty	Do not read from notes or search answers. Eye movement and typing sounds are noticeable, and proctored tests may flag it.
If disconnected	Rejoin immediately using the same link. If you cannot, email or message the coordinator with a short, polite note.

Tip: In online interviews there is a small delay. Wait a moment after the interviewer stops talking before you start, so you do not talk over each other.

7. Group discussion (GD) tips

Some companies use a GD as an elimination round before interviews. Usually 8 to 12 candidates discuss a topic for 10 to 20 minutes while evaluators watch. They are not looking for the loudest person. They look for content, clarity, listening and the ability to move the discussion forward.

Common topic types

- **Current affairs and society:** for example, "Work from home: boon or bane", "Impact of social media on youth".
- **Technology:** for example, "Will AI replace software jobs?", "Digital payments in rural India".
- **Abstract:** for example, "Zero", "Red", "Black and white". Here you interpret the word in a creative but sensible way.
- **Case-based:** a short business problem the group must solve together.

What helps

- **Use the first minute to think.** Note two or three points with an example or fact for each.
- **Start only if you have a clear point.** Opening the GD well (defining the topic, suggesting angles) is valuable. Opening with nothing to say hurts.
- **Quality over quantity.** Three to four well-made points are better than ten interruptions.
- **Build on others:** "Adding to what she said...", "I partly agree, but...". This shows listening.
- **Bring in quiet members:** "We haven't heard from you yet, what do you think?" Evaluators notice this.
- **Disagree politely,** with a reason. Never attack a person.
- **Summarise at the end** if you get the chance: balanced, covering both sides, without adding new points.

What hurts

- Shouting, cutting people off repeatedly, or dominating.
- Staying silent the whole time.
- Quoting statistics you are not sure about. A wrong number damages credibility.
- Speaking only to the evaluators instead of the group.
- Switching your stand without a reason.

Tip: Read one good newspaper's opinion page for 15 minutes a day in the weeks before placements. It gives you both content and ready vocabulary for GDs.

8. Mistakes to avoid

Mistake	Why it hurts	Do this instead
Lying or exaggerating on the resume	One follow-up question exposes it, and trust is lost for the whole interview.	Only list what you can explain in detail.
Memorised, robotic answers	Sounds insincere; you get stuck if the question is worded differently.	Memorise key points, not sentences.
Speaking badly about college, teachers or a past employer	Signals you may do the same about this company.	Stay neutral and focus on what you learnt.
Very long answers	The interviewer loses interest and has less time for other questions.	Aim for 1 to 2 minutes; offer more detail if they want it.
One-word answers	Gives them nothing to evaluate.	Answer, then add one example or reason.
Not knowing the company	Shows low interest.	20 minutes of research before every interview.
Saying "we" for everything	They cannot tell what you did.	Use "I" for your actions, "we" for team results.
Arguing with the interviewer	Even if you are right, it looks poor.	"I see your point. My understanding was..., could you help me understand?"
Bluffing when you don't know	Interviewers usually know the answer.	"I am not sure about this, but I would approach it by..." or simply "I don't know yet, I will read about it."
Asking only about salary and leave	Looks like you care only about benefits.	Ask about training, work and growth first.

9. Honest preparation, not tricks

You will find advice online to give "safe" answers that hide everything. That is not a good plan. Interviewers talk to many candidates and can usually tell a rehearsed act from a real person. What works over time:

- Know your own story: projects, choices, mistakes and what you learnt.
- Present it clearly and positively, without lying.
- Where you have a real limitation (location, a bond you cannot accept), say it politely. A good fit matters for you too, not just the company.
- Practise aloud. Record yourself on your phone answering five questions, then watch it. You will spot filler words and long answers immediately.
- Do mock interviews with friends or seniors and give each other honest feedback.

10. Last-week checklist

- Re-read your resume line by line. For every item, prepare a 1-minute explanation and expect "why" and "how" questions.
- Finalise your "Tell me about yourself" (60 to 90 seconds). Practise it aloud at least five times, without reading.
- Write 5 to 6 STAR stories: deadline, conflict, failure, teamwork, leadership, learning something new.
- Prepare honest answers for strengths, weakness, five years, relocation, shifts, bond and salary.
- Research each company you are interviewing with: what it does, 2 or 3 specific facts, the role offered.
- Prepare two questions to ask the interviewer.
- Read the job conditions shared by the placement cell, including the service agreement terms.
- Do at least one mock interview with a friend or senior, and one recorded self-practice.
- Online interview: test camera, mic, internet, lighting and background the day before. Keep a backup connection.
- In-person interview: iron formal clothes, print 3 copies of your resume, pack ID and documents the night before.
- Sleep properly the night before. A clear mind helps more than last-minute cramming.

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